antiaircraft artillery has been made by Fidel Castro in case of their invasion of Cuba," wrote Pliev. He was going to do the same. "In case of a strike against our installations on the part of American aviation, the decision has been made to employ all available antiaircraft resources," reported Pliev. He believed that the American intelligence services had identified "some areas in which Comrade Statsenko's installations were located." Pliev had no right to use nuclear weapons without authorization from Moscow but could launch his SAM missiles and was prepared to do so.[13]

Pliev's report was presented by Marshal Rodion Malinovsky to Khrushchev and the members of the Central Committee's Presidium as they met at the Kremlin that day for their now regular session to discuss the Cuban situation. The Presidium approved General Pliev's actions but instructed him not to escalate the possible conventional conflict into a nuclear one. He was once again prohibited from using nuclear weapons, including tactical ones, as well as aircraft without explicit instructions from Moscow. And the supervision did not end there: three separate telegrams were sent to Pliev. "Stop all work on deployment of R-12 and R-14—you are aggravating the United Nations," read one of the orders sent to Cuba by Malinovsky. "Camouflage everything carefully, work only at night." Pliev was also reminded that he had to send the *Aleksandrovsk*, which had brought the nuclear warheads for intermediate-range missiles to Cuba, back to the Soviet Union.[14]

Khrushchev was uncharacteristically calm that day. He wanted to keep Pliev from complicating the diplomatic game he was now playing with Kennedy and at the United Nations. He also saw a sign of hope and new opportunity in the reports coming from Cuba, no matter how alarmist they had been. It was afternoon in Moscow when the Presidium discussed the report. The night of October 26 and the morning of October 27 had come and gone with no news of an American attack on the island. "We must take into account that the US did not attack Cuba," Khrushchev told his colleagues. "Could they attack us right now?" he asked at another point in the discussion and immediately gave his own response: "I think they will not bring themselves to do it."

Unlike Castro and Pliev, Khrushchev no longer believed that an invasion was imminent. That view gave him some breathing space and